3.1 Intro to Time Management

Overview

Time management isn't a new concept. You've likely heard that good time management is an important key to success. In fact, you're probably often reminded of the importance of time through the following common phrases:

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- Time flies when you're having fun.
- Time waits for no one.
- I've got nothing but time!
- Time is money.
- You can't make up for lost time.
- It's about time!
- Time is of the essence.

Now that you've started college, you probably realize you'll need good time management skills to stay on top of your personal, professional, and academic responsibilities. It's perfectly natural to worry about how you'll manage this, so don't feel alone. In the following video, veteran faculty member, Brad Carroll, talks about the importance of managing your time.

Figure 3.1.1: Managing Your Time

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Transcript

What is Time Management?

Time management is defined as:

> The planning, prioritizing, and scheduling of tasks to create work efficiency in an environment of competing demands. Sometimes called *time budgeting*, time management enables people to efficiently complete tasks and meet deadlines, contributing to success at home, school, or the workplace and reduced levels of stress (Comstock, 2019).

Now that you've been introduced to the definition of time management, you're probably wondering how you can "work smarter, not harder" to get everything done in the time you have. The following sections should help you better understand how to accomplish this.

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3.2 Taking a Look at Your Day/Week/Month

Did you know that there are 168 hours in every week? It is up to each of us to decide how to best use those 168 hours. Most of us say at some point that, "There isn't enough time in the day." However, when we take stock of the amount of time we spend on our social media accounts and answering texts and emails, it can be eye-opening. There have been many research studies that investigate the number of hours that Americans use their electronic devices. The hours spent vary, but Fisher (2019) says, "we spend as much as 12 hours a day in front of our TVs and computers" (para. 3). That statistic may seem shocking, but when you start to look at your own daily and weekly time usage, you may be able to relate to it.

There are numerous time management charts that can be found on the internet. In addition, there are many time management phone apps that could be helpful. Find a chart or app that suits your style and input your daily tasks and activities and the time you spend on each one. Be sure to include all of the "must-do", non-negotiable, and inflexible tasks (work, commuting, sleep) in the chart. Then, plug in the activities you also must do but that are more flexible. When you have included as much as you can, you will see where you have time for hobbies, social media, and other free-choice activities.

Figure 3.2.1: Time Management Chart

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Time Management Chart

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
8:00 AM							
8:30 AM							
9:00 AM							
9:30 AM							
10:00 AM							
10:30 AM							
11:00 AM							
11:30 AM							
12:00 PM							
12:30 PM							
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6:30 PM							
7:00 PM							
7:30 PM							
8:00 PM							

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Feel free to download a copy of this Time Management Chart to record your weekly activities.

3.3 Mindful Use of Time

Distractions

Everyone has distractions in their lives. Whether it's television, video games, social media, or spending time with family and friends, these distractions can interfere with your success. It's not uncommon to want to socialize with your friends or watch TV instead of writing paper. You may also be running on only a few hours of sleep after working extra shifts or getting up with a sick child. These are all realities of life that will test your ability to focus on your schoolwork. It's important that you develop the skills you'll need to manage life's distractions.

Strategies for Minimizing Distractions

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Gore et al. (2016) provide several recommendations for managing distractions.

- **Enlist the support of others.**

  For example, you may want to set a family study time when everyone remains quiet as they read or study. This can be a great way to help keep you on the studying track.

- **Turn off electronics and devices.**

  Turn off any electronics that can distract you from studying. You may even want to place your phone in another room. Some students strategically place notes on the electronic devices around their home to remind them of their most common distractions and help keep them on track.

- **Designate a distraction-free zone.**

  Set up a study space that's free of distractions. You can put up curtains to block out extra light, place room dividers, and have noise-cancelling headphones on hand.

Prioritizing

Prioritizing your must-do tasks by day, week, or month is an important part of effective time management and avoiding wasting time. Some students describe that they spend too much time on social media and the time just slips away; before they know it, an hour is gone!

A great solution for many students is to flip it around. When they come home from work, they open their student portal, and before they know it, they are in class, posting a discussion message or reading a chapter in the e-textbook. Then, when the discussion posts are done or the assignment is completed, the student can spend time on social media or relax with another fun activity.

Strategies for Prioritizing

- **Make to-do lists**: Make a list of all of the "must-do" activities for the day and week. Gardner and Barefoot (2014) note that, "Almost all successful people keep a daily to-do list. The list may be in paper or electronic form. Get in the habit of creating and maintaining your own daily list of appointments, obligations, and activities" (p. 39).
- **Organize your lists:** Order your activities in a way that makes the most sense for you. You can organize them in the order you plan to complete the activities or in order of importance. One option is to write all your must-do tasks on sticky notes and move them around to prioritize. When a task is done, throw away the sticky note or cross the item off your list—it feels good to be able to do that!
- **Say "no":** Don't overextend yourself. Gardner and Barefoot (2014) state, "Students underestimate how much time it will take to earn the grades they want in college and have overscheduled themselves with

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work and other commitments, leaving them little to no flexible time to use when they need more time" (p. 30). As an adult student with a family and/or job in addition to school, it may be even more of a challenge not to overextend yourself. Pay attention to your stress levels and try different strategies until you find the schedule that works best for you. Avoiding procrastination can help with this, too.

- **Be flexible:** In life, unexpected things occur. Children and aging parents may need attention or you may have work obligations you didn't foresee, and your schedule can get thrown off. When that happens, take care of your needs and get right back to your schedule as soon as possible.

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PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 3.3.1: Time Management

1) Why is time management important to you as a new college student?

- Time management will guarantee I receive high grades on all my assignments.
- Time management will help me complete tasks, meet deadlines, succeed at achieving my goals, and reduce stress.
- Time management will force me to get everything done in a day.
- Managing time isn't important to me as a student. It's only important in the workplace.

2) Mason is struggling to finish her homework on time. She's been setting aside time every evening to work on her school projects, but it can be difficult for her to concentrate when her children are watching TV. What advice would you give Mason to improve her situation?

- She should wear noise-cancelling headphones to block out the sounds of her children and TV.
- She should increase the amount of time she sets aside for schoolwork.

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- She should establish a family study time when everyone spends time quietly working on their schoolwork.
- She already has a dedicated time to work on her schoolwork. There's not much more she can do.

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3) Everyone has their daily and weekly "must-do" tasks. Between work, family, and school, it can sometimes be difficult to complete all these tasks. One way to help manage your "must-do" tasks is to create a prioritization system. Which statement below is a good example of prioritization?

- I create a schedule of everything I have to do and rank my tasks in order of importance (high, medium, or low).
- I keep all my must-do tasks in my head and complete them as they come to mind.
- I complete my assignments the night before they are due.
- I write down my must-do tasks, put them in a hat, and complete each task in the order I pull them out.

4) The Fourth of July is coming up and you have plans to spend the holiday with your family. You also have an assignment due on July 5th. You haven't started the assignment, so you're feeling stressed about finishing it on time. What is the best strategy to address this situation?

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- Wait until the last minute and do your assignment. That way you won't have to worry about it while you enjoy the holiday.
- Plan in advance by carefully writing out a schedule of tasks you need to complete prior to the holiday. This will help you to complete your tasks, enjoy the holiday, and submit your assignment on time.
- Spend the holiday working on your assignment while your family celebrates around you.
- Write a note to your instructor explaining why you won't be able to submit your assignment on time.

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5) What are some ways to get the most out of your limited studying time?

- Study during your work breaks and lunch time.
- Work ahead on assignments and complete the readings early in the week.
- Turn off your cell phone, TV, and music to avoid distractions.
- All of the above.

3.4 The Relationship Between Time and Stress

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When we are stressed, we don't feel motivated. When we are stressed, we may be unorganized and tend to procrastinate. When we are stressed, we aren't alert and cannot retain information that we are learning. Examples of how stress affects us could go on and on, but you get the point. Stress is counterproductive in our lives, and as a college student, stress most definitely works against you.

So, how effectively do you manage your stress? WebMD offers a Stress Management Quiz you may find helpful. This quiz asks you to answer several questions about your day-to-day life in order to assess how you manage

and handle stress.

Here are some additional considerations for limiting stress:

Build a schedule to help balance your priorities.

When you are setting your schedule, you need to balance your priorities. It's easier to schedule your action items when the priorities seem to "jump" right out at you. However, you may have some activities due at the same time, and it can be difficult to decide which to do first and which to put aside until later.

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How can you balance your priorities when you have several competing priorities due at the same time?

Be realistic about time commitments.

The amount of time it takes to complete tasks has a big impact on you how you plan your daily schedule, and it's important to be realistic about how much time tasks will take. One method that might be applied is the 2-for-1 rule. Simply stated, you should reserve at least two hours of study time each week for every hour in class (or class credit hour). For a 3-credit hour course like GEN/201, you should reserve 6 hours a week for study. As you record your tasks, ask yourself the following questions: Do you find you are spending two hours each week on study time per credit hour? Are you spending more or less time? Do you feel the time you are spending is enough? If not, what changes can you make?

Stick to your schedule.

Sticking close to your plans will help keep you on track to complete all of your tasks by their deadlines, without getting overwhelmed. As you develop your study routine, you may find it becomes easier to stick to your schedule because you become better at estimating how much time tasks will take to complete. At the same time, it is important to remain flexible (things do come up that need more immediate attention) and not to get discouraged if plans and tasks have to be rearranged.

Don't attempt to multitask.

There was a time when multitasking was celebrated in the workplace. We now know that we are much less efficient, and our quality of work suffers, when we work on more than one task at a time. Multitasking slows your progress toward achieving your daily, weekly, and monthly goals. Give each task your full attention before moving on to other tasks.

Check tasks off.

It is important to check off tasks as they are completed. There are two good reasons for this. First, you are assured that the task has been completed and you can move on. And second, it is rewarding to see all that you've accomplished as you move through the week. The feeling of accomplishment gives you motivation and momentum to see you through your next tasks.

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Be sure to sleep and to eat healthy foods.

As you continue to ponder this week's material, don't forget to take care of yourself. Taking care of yourself is an important part of your work-school-life balance. With a busy lifestyle, it's easy to let go of sleep and healthy eating habits. No matter what your circumstance is, if you are not well-rested and eating healthy food, you will be

stressed. When you are stressed, everything seems more difficult and takes longer to complete. To guard against having your schoolwork suffer, try to eat nutritiously and get enough sleep each night.

Exercise.

What do you do for exercise? Physical activity increases blood flow to the brain allowing you to have more energy and to think more clearly. Additionally, exercising can help you to sleep better, which means you will be more alert during the day. Finally, exercise can reduce stress. Be sure you are getting regular exercise to stay healthy and have more energy for your classes and other commitments in your life.

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Pro Tip: By putting exercise as a task into your time management tool, you are more likely to do it!

Schedule time for fun.

It is important to take breaks for personal time and hobbies! Just be careful to coordinate that time with your current schedule. There may be times where you put off fun activities to meet your short-term goals, but it is important that you regularly spend some time on yourself as well. You will be less likely to meet goals if you are overworked or stressed out. It's important to refresh your body and mind, as it can help you stay focused when you really need to.

It may be a good idea to ask yourself the following questions:

- Do you make personal time a priority in your schedule?
- How do you decompress and refresh yourself before and after tackling a tough goal?

Use a grit mindset to help overcome stress.

It is normal for college students to experience stress. Falling behind on tasks can generate feelings of stress, but there are several things you can do to help alleviate those feelings. If you are feeling stressed, remember the concept of *grit*. As you recall, Duckworth (2013) defines grit as the "perseverance and passion for long-term goals." Of course, long-term goals are comprised of short-term goals, and those short-term goals are comprised of our daily, weekly, and monthly tasks.

Don't be too hard on yourself if you fall behind on a task. Stop. Breathe. Think of the big picture. Then, take the time to reprioritize your tasks and focus on completing one task at a time.

Study and Classroom Time

Review the tips below for managing your study and class time. Some of these tips may be new to you, while some have been discussed already and will serve as reminders to you as you finish this week of GEN/201.

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- Turn off all extra devices (phone, TV, radio, etc.), or place them in another room.
- Determine if you can study with music in the background.
- Create a studying/class to-do list.
- Learn assignment and discussion requirements and due dates with each new class you start.
- Ask questions if you need clarification. Lack of understanding results in wasted time.
- Discover your best ways of studying and prioritizing your work. Do you like to tackle the big projects when you are fresh, or do you prefer to complete the small tasks first and get them off your plate?
- Remember that all social media can wait until studying is completed. Use it as a reward.

- Take advantage of unexpected gifts of time. For example, use wait time to your advantage to study while on lunch break or while watching your children practice soccer or dance.
- Avoid multitasking. Focus on one thing at a time.
- Log into class every day, even if it is just to check your private messages (which are very important to check often!).

Other important considerations:

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- **Ask for support.**

  Do you have a support system? Think about the people in your life who are there for you and believe in what you are doing. They can help encourage you and help you overcome procrastination. You may have people who you can ask for help for things like childcare and grocery shopping, to allow you more time to study. Be willing to ask for support in meeting your goals.

- **Just say no.**

  Learn how to say "no" to participating in activities that are not directly critical to your goals. This is easier said than done, since we often feel guilty for turning down a family member or friend. However, you are on a mission to make your life better, and as a result the lives of your family members, so keep your focus on the big picture of earning your degree.

- **Become familiar with the Blackboard platform.**

  Know where everything is located in the classroom. The sooner you learn the location of everything, the more efficient you will be when completing course tasks, which, of course, will save you time.

Final Thoughts: Managing Time

The repercussions of poor time management can affect your success as a student, so it's important that you develop a time management strategy early in your program and stick to it. Good time management skills will also help you as you move forward in your personal and professional life; get in the practice of continually adjusting and improving those skills as you experience life changes, big and small.

3.5 Goal Setting

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Overview

Setting clearly defined and measurable goals is an important skill for you as a student to possess. The goal of this section is to familiarize you with several tools, resources, and strategies that will help you set effective goals. You will explore the purpose and process of developing, applying, and evaluating the goals you set for yourself. Moreover, you will gain a better understanding of how goal setting can help you become a more productive student.

Goal setting is a process that involves determining what you want to accomplish and developing a plan, with deadlines, to help you achieve that goal. Setting goals can have a positive effect on your motivation; help improve your mental health; and increase your personal, professional, and academic success (Riopel, 2020).

Benefits of Goal Setting

There are many benefits to establishing and achieving goals. McGlynn and Kelly (2017) highlight a few key benefits:

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- Provides direction: Creating goals that have clearly defined objectives and deadlines will assist in a successful outcome.
- Creates focus: When setting goals, it is important that you establish what you want to achieve and then focus on how to make it happen.
- Improves decision making: Once you have established your goals, it becomes easier to make positive decisions and overcome obstacles.
- Gives you control of your future: By setting goals, you take ownership over what you do and achieve, whether that be related to school, work, or home.
- Provides motivation: Goals provide the ability to accomplish your priorities and help to keep you on track and motivated to continue.
- Gives you a sense of personal satisfaction and improved self-esteem: The more priorities you can accomplish in obtaining your goals, the more confident you will be in the future.
- Gives you a sense of purpose: Goal setting helps provide a clear path and purpose to be able to reach your full potential.

3.6 Setting and Executing Goals

Life Goals

Have you ever had anyone ask you, “Where do you see yourself in ten years?” While this is a relatively common question, it’s difficult to effectively answer without an understanding of your goals. Goals can include any personal, professional, or academic milestones that will contribute to your overall success. They contribute to your long-term vision for your life, and can also help with your short-term motivation.

Short-Term Goals

Establishing small, obtainable goals can help you to achieve your more challenging long-term goals. After you make the effort to visualize the end goal, you can then break it down into manageable and organized tasks. These short-term goals can be set for each day, week, or month, and they serve as milestones on the road map to achieving your longer-term goals.

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A classic example of using short-term goals to help achieve a long-term ambition involves improving your healthy habits. You could set short-term goals such as: exercise 30 minutes a day for 5 days of the week, drink 75–100 ounces of water each day, get up and stretch for 2 minutes during each hour that you’re working or studying, and bike to work every Friday. These short-term goals can be measured and logged in a health app and can keep you on track towards your longer-term goal of improving your health and fitness.

Examples of Short-Term Goals for School:

- I will complete one course every 5 weeks until I complete my program.
- I will complete all assignments and activities each week of class.
- I will successfully pass each course with a C+ or better.
- I will reward myself every 6 months to remain motivated and focused.

Remember to be specific when setting goals and ask yourself: Who? What? Why? Where? When? How? The goals you set should be tangible and realistic. Don't set yourself up for failure by setting unrealistic or ill-defined goals.

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Long-Term Goals

Long-term goals provide direction and a clear plan for what you hope to achieve in the future. However, it's important to understand they can't be achieved right away. After all, how realistic would it be for someone to achieve a short-term goal to complete an Ironman Triathlon in a week? Long-term goals should be viewed as major accomplishments you plan to complete in 1, 5, or even 10 years. Think of the major things you want to accomplish in your life and use those as the basis for your long-term goals.

Example of a Long-Term Goal for School:

- I will graduate with my Bachelor of Science in Business degree from the University of Phoenix in 4 years and gain skills in management theory, human resources management, accounting, marketing, and business decision-making.

Don't forget, you will need to establish a set of short-term goals to keep you moving towards each long-term goal.

Accomplishing Your Goals

Learning and practicing habits that relate to your goals is critical to your success in accomplishing those goals. Some strategies for this include:

- Set a schedule with deadlines for completing short-term goals along the path to completing your long-term goal. Accomplishing the smaller goals will help keep you motivated.
- Tackle your more challenging tasks headfirst.
- Take stock of the resources you have and how you can use them. Then, use your support system. Not only can your college advisors, instructors, co-workers, family, and friends help with setting your goals, they can also have a positive impact on your attitude, motivation, and success in accomplishing both your short- and long-term goals.

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Figure 3.6.1: Reflect on Your Learning

Reflect on Your Learning

Consider your degree program and career path. Visualize yourself after you earn your degree, and establish a long-term career goal you hope to achieve. Write your long-term goal, and then write several short-term goals that will support it. Consider the following as you think about your post-degree goal:

- What will you be doing?
- What job will you have?
- How will you ensure achievement of your goal?

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3.7 Evaluating, Assessing, and Updating Your Goals

Setbacks and Goal Adjustment

Goal setting and time management are challenges, and you will experience both wins and setbacks. You'll need to be prepared to stay motivated, inspired, and persistent—even when you may want to give up.

Some of the most successful people in our society experienced failure as they started out, but with persistence and resilience they ultimately achieved their goals and more. Some examples include:

- Abraham Lincoln failed in business in 1831 and 1833. He was also defeated while running for elected seats in 1832, 1838, 1840, 1843, 1855, 1856, and 1858. In 1860, Lincoln was elected president of the United States.
- The manuscripts for the Harry Potter books were rejected by multiple publishing companies. Author J. K. Rowling persisted until she eventually found a publisher. Her books became the best-selling book series in history, selling over 500 million copies and translated into over 80 languages.
- In 2006, a young student named Stefani Germanotta signed a deal with Def Jam Records. After three months, the company decided that her style was not a good fit and cancelled the contract. After that, Germanotta spent a couple of years playing in small clubs, making little money, and crafting her performance skills. She also worked behind the scenes writing songs for other artists. Eventually her talent and efforts were noticed and there was another record deal and a new name for her act: Lady Gaga.
- In 1978, Michael Jordan was a sophomore trying out for his high school varsity basketball team. He didn't make the cut. When he finally made the team the next year, he sat on the bench, getting hardly any playing time. Despite the setbacks, Jordan kept working and landed a basketball scholarship to UNC and a #3 draft pick in the NBA while he was still in school. Jordan led his college team to multiple national titles, and he eventually represented the United States in the Olympic Games as part of the 1992 "Dream Team."

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Setbacks are inevitable, and there will be times when you'll have to adjust your goal path. Sticking with realistic and achievable goals requires you to routinely conduct a self-evaluation, and then update and alter your goals if necessary. For example, let's say your goal is to save $100 a month for the next six months, but then your hours are cut or you lose your job. Although saving $100 per month is no longer realistic in the short term, it is a long-term goal that still can happen. This is a good time to reevaluate, adjust your deadlines, and change your short-term goals to focus on your job situation first; this can then make your long-term goal of saving money possible.

Final Thoughts: Goal Setting

Effective goal setting is an essential skill to have as a student and in your personal and professional life; when you set a goal, you focus on what you want to achieve, and you create a path that can get you there. As you move forward, it's important to be continuously developing and expanding your set of goals. Start to consider the next short-term goal you will work on to assist in achievement of your long-term goals. Continue to analyze, question, problem-solve, evaluate, and reflect on your current and future goals. Practice your goal setting skills often and celebrate your accomplishments!

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PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 3.7.1: Goal Setting

1) Goal setting is the process of deciding what to accomplish, and then devising a plan to make it happen. When is the right time to set goals?

- I should strive to set personal, professional, and academic goals throughout my life.
- Goals should only be set for major events in my life.
- Goals should only be set when there is a problem I am facing and need help to solve.
- Goals should only be set once a year.

2) James has decided to set a goal to buy a new car before the end of the year. In what ways will setting this goal benefit James?

- Setting this goal can provide James with direction and motivation.
- Setting this goal can give James direction, which will also help improve his decision making.
- Setting this goal can help James focus and give him more control over his future.

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- All of the above.

3) Sally wants to set a long-term goal to pay off the $1200 balance on her credit card in 12 months. How can she use goal setting to pay down that balance?

- Set a short-term goal to make a one-time $1200 payment at the end of the month.
- Find a different goal because the balance is too high.
- Set a goal to save $110 a month and apply it to her credit card balance for 12 months.
- Set a goal to save $100 a month and apply it to her credit card balance for a year.

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4) Most students have a long-term goal of advancing in their career. What is a good example of a short-term professional goal you could set for the next 5 weeks that will support a long-term goal of moving up in your career?

- Set a goal to update your resume using the services available in PhoenixLink.
- Set a goal to make changes to your LinkedIn Profile to reflect that you are currently working towards a degree.
- Take the time to send an email to your supervisor sharing your long-term career goals and asking for their support in achieving them.
- All of the above.

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5) Ruby set a long-term career goal to become a Department Director at the

telecommunications company she works for in the next 3 years. She is currently working on her Bachelor of Science in Business Management degree but was recently passed over for an interview for a promotion because she hasn't completed her degree. She is discouraged and is beginning to think her long-term goal may not be realistic. What advice can you give Ruby about reaching goals?

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- Becoming a Department Director is a great career. The goal was set for a reason. Keep those reasons in mind and push through the work.
- Although it is important to set goals and work hard to accomplish the goals we established, goals can be altered and changed. Maybe, becoming a Department Director will take more than 3 years.

Figure 3.7.1: Reflect on Your Learning

What will you do if you happen to hit a "bump in the road" along your college journey? Why do you think honest self-evaluation is an important part of setting realistic goals?

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*****YOU HAVE NOW COMPLETED ALL OF THE READINGS FOR WEEK 2*****

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